

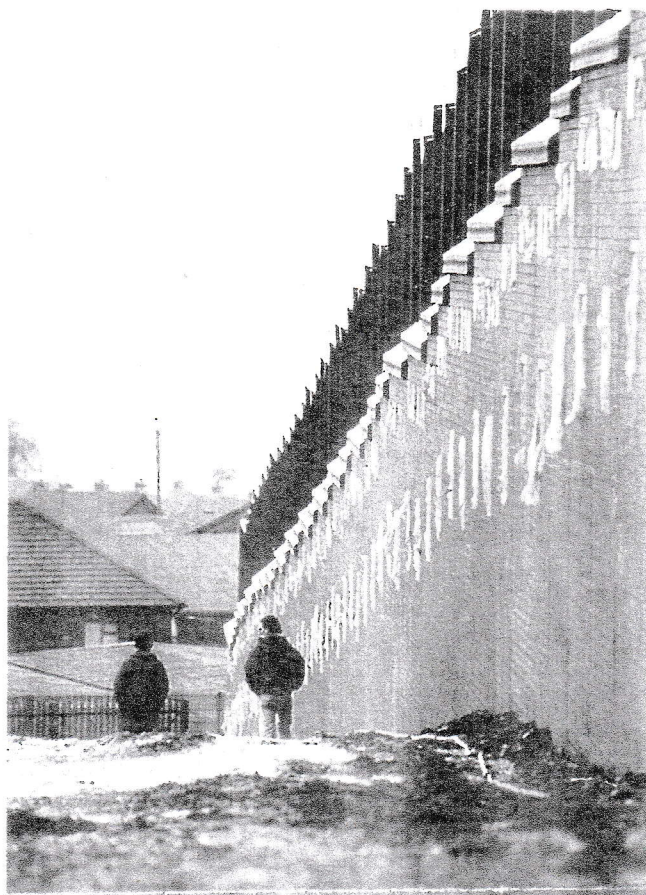
Kevin Roche, 16

1 I GO to a Catholic boys' school in west
Belfast in the Falls Road area near
where I live. My main ambition is to
leave school and start work: most of all I'd
5 like to have some sort of business of my
own, say a handyman's¹ or decorator's or
something of that sort, because if you're
going to go round looking for a job you
don't really stand much chance of getting
10 one. My father's been out of work for over
five years now: he used to be in the docks²,
but he got laid off and hasn't been able to
find anything at all since then. As well as the high unemployment there is in
Belfast, it's much harder too to get something if you're a Catholic, because
15 most of the big employers are Protestant and there's a lot of discrimination.
I've two brothers older than me, and neither of them is working either.

If I had the chance I'd like to go to England. I know there's unemploy-
ment there too, but from what I hear from those who've been, it's nothing
like as bad as it is here. Most of all though the place I'd really like to go is
20 America: four years ago I went on a three-week holiday with a school party
to a children's farm camp near Boston, and I've always had the idea since
that if I could once get to America, I could get forestry³ work or something
like that, and get away from Belfast for ever.

That's something that I'd do in a split second if the chance ever arose,
25 I wouldn't even stop to think about it. I can't see any future here at all,
except civil war. I think one day the British'll decide they've had enough
and they'll go, and then I think the Protestants will take over the running of
the country again, and do everything they can to keep themselves in
power. They've got too strong a grip on the country for anyone to be able
30 to make them let go: I don't agree with the IRA and the violence and all the
rest of it, but I can see their point of view. I'm not old enough to vote yet,
but when I am it'll be for Sinn Féin because I think they're the only ones
who are for the working people.

At the moment I've got a Protestant girlfriend, but I wouldn't like my
35 parents to know that, and she hasn't told hers.



- 1. handyman: *homme à tout faire*
- 2. docks: *docks, quais*
- 3. forestry: *sylviculture*